

# BOUGAINVILLEA

*Bougainvillea spectabilis* / *B. glabra*

## Quick Facts

|                 |                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|-----------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Scientific Name | Bougainvillea spectabilis / B. glabra                                                                                                                                                           |
| Family          | Nyctaginaceae                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| Common Names    | Bougainvillea, Paper Flower, Bugarvilia                                                                                                                                                         |
| Native Origin   | South America — Brazil, Peru, Ecuador                                                                                                                                                           |
| Colors          | Pink, magenta, purple, red, orange, white, yellow, and bi-coloured varieties. The vivid colour comes from bracts (modified leaves), not petals.                                                 |
| Height          | 3 to 12 metres as a climber; dwarf potted varieties reach 60 to 90 cm.                                                                                                                          |
| Blooming Season | October to May in India (peak November to March). In cooler hill stations, flowering occurs mainly in spring. In tropical coastal areas such as Goa and Kerala, it can bloom nearly year-round. |

## Distribution in India

Widely cultivated across all of India, particularly in Maharashtra, Rajasthan, Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, West Bengal, and Goa. Extremely common in urban landscapes, gardens, and highway dividers.

## Description and Overview

Bougainvillea is one of the most spectacular flowering plants in the tropical and subtropical world. It is a vigorous, thorny, woody climber or sprawling shrub belonging to the family Nyctaginaceae. The plant is renowned for its brilliantly coloured bracts — modified leaves that surround the tiny, inconspicuous, white or yellow true flowers at the centre. Many people mistakenly identify the bracts as the petals.

The plant was first described scientifically by the French botanist Philibert Commercon during the first circumnavigation of the globe by Louis Antoine de Bougainville in the 1760s, after whom it is named. It was introduced to India during the British colonial period and has since naturalised thoroughly across the country's tropical and subtropical regions.

Bougainvillea is highly drought-tolerant once established and thrives in poor, well-drained soils with full sunlight. It actually blooms more prolifically when slightly stressed by water restriction. Excess watering or fertilising with nitrogen encourages leaf growth at the expense of flowers. The plant is trained over pergolas, walls, fences, and arches and is a favourite for highway beautification projects across India.

In India, it holds cultural significance in several regions and is frequently used in religious and decorative floral arrangements. Its hardy nature and year-round availability in warm climates make it one of the most commercially grown ornamental plants in South Asian nurseries.

## Blooming Season and Conditions

October to May in India (peak November to March). In cooler hill stations, flowering occurs mainly in spring. In tropical coastal areas such as Goa and Kerala, it can bloom nearly year-round.

## Cultivation

Bougainvillea prefers full sun — at least 6 hours of direct sunlight daily. It grows best in slightly acidic to neutral soil (pH 5.5 to 6.5). In India, it is propagated mainly through semi-hardwood stem cuttings taken between June and August. The cutting is treated with rooting hormone and planted in a mix of sand and coir.

Pruning immediately after each bloom cycle encourages the next flush of flowering. In India's monsoon climate, plants may show reduced flowering from July to September due to heavy rainfall and reduced sunlight, but resume vigorously in October. Frost damage occurs below 0 degrees Celsius, so in northern hill regions such as Shimla and Darjeeling it is grown as an annual or given winter protection.

## Uses and Applications

**Ornamental:** The primary use is aesthetic. It is used in landscape design, garden borders, trellises, bonsai, and hanging baskets.

**Traditional medicine:** In Brazil and Mexico, decoctions of the bracts are used to treat coughs, sore throats, and bronchitis. In India, the leaves are used in folk remedies for diabetes, stomach ailments, and liver complaints.

**Environmental:** The dense thorny growth makes excellent security hedges. The plant stabilises slopes and reduces soil erosion in landscaped areas.

## Interesting Facts

- The colourful parts that most people call flowers are actually bracts (modified leaves). The true flowers are tiny, tubular, and usually white or pale yellow.
- There are over 300 named cultivars of Bougainvillea worldwide, differing in bract colour, leaf variegation, and growth habit.
- Bougainvillea was introduced to India in the 19th century and is now so widespread that many people consider it a native Indian plant.
- It is the official flower of the city of Pune, Maharashtra, and is used extensively in Mumbai's coastal landscape.
- In Singapore and Thailand, Bougainvillea is a national symbol and used extensively in public landscaping.

---

Source: Flower AI Knowledge Base — BOUGAINVILLEA entry. Scientific name: *Bougainvillea spectabilis* / *B. glabra*. Family: Nyctaginaceae.